INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #8 · PARENTING

“I have ruined my children.”

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Where it often comes from

Looking back on yelling, divorce, absence, addiction, neglect, or hard years, some parents decide the damage is permanent. Guilt can be especially heavy when a child is hurting now and we can see the connection. Shame then says, “It is too late and they are broken because of me.”

What Scripture teaches

God speaks of restoration: “I will repay you for the years eaten by locusts.” The Lord says, “Keep your voice from weeping and your eyes from tears, for the reward for your work will come… So there is hope for your future, declares the LORD, and your children will return.” Paul writes that “if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation,” and Joseph told his brothers, “what you intended against me for evil, God intended for good.” This is not a denial of real harm. It is a promise that God can redeem what we cannot, and that repentance, repair, and prayer can change a story that is not finished.

> *“I will repay you for the years eaten by locusts— the swarming locust, the young locust, the destroying locust, and the devouring locust— My great army that I sent against you”* (Joel 2:25).

Also see

> “This is what the LORD says: ‘Keep your voice from weeping and your eyes from tears, for the reward for your work will come, declares the LORD. Then your children will return from the land of the enemy. So there is hope for your future, declares the LORD, and your children will return to their own land.’” (Jeremiah 31:16–17).

> “As for you, what you intended against me for evil, God intended for good, in order to accomplish a day like this—to preserve the lives of many people” (Genesis 50:20).

> “‘Do not call to mind the former things; pay no attention to the things of old. Behold, I am about to do something new; even now it is coming. Do you not see it? Indeed, I will make a way in the wilderness and streams in the desert.’” (Isaiah 43:18–19).

> “And we know that God works all things together for the good of those who love Him, who are called according to His purpose” (Romans 8:28).

Common self-statements

- The damage is permanent.
- They will never forgive me.
- I cannot undo what I did.
- My children are hurt because of me.
- It is too late to make it right.
- I destroyed their childhood.

Common logical errors

- Catastrophizing: Treating real harm as irreversible ruin.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that my children will never recover.

- Labeling: Calling myself a ruiner.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling terrible and concluding the damage is total.

Challenging questions

- What specifically do I believe I did, and what is the actual impact on each child?
- Have I acknowledged it to my children, and how did they respond?
- What strengths and good memories do my children also have?
- What does God say about restoring lost years?
- What can I do now to repair, listen, and love?
- What is not in my control?

Truth summary

> I have made real mistakes, and some have hurt my children. But I have not ruined them beyond God's ability to restore. I can repent, repair what I can, listen, and pray, trusting God to redeem what I cannot.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Parenting
- Forgiveness
- Repent
- Confession
- Mercy

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Parenting
- Trouble/Hardship

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

All Things New — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's renewing work offers hope beyond failure, decay, and loss.

Broken Things — Matthew West
God can work through imperfect people without waiting for them to become flawless.

Forgiveness — Matthew West
Ask God for help releasing resentment while working through real hurt.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I have ruined my children"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I have ruined my children." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What exactly do I regret?
- ☐ What is the impact on each child?
- ☐ Have I apologized?
- ☐ What strengths do my children have?
- ☐ What can I repair now?
- ☐ What can I trust to God?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God can restore the years the locusts have eaten.
- ☐ There is hope for my future and my children's.
- ☐ Repentance and repair matter.
- ☐ God can turn evil to good.
- ☐ I am a new creation in Christ.
- ☐ The story is not finished.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Joel 2:25

  "I will repay you for the years eaten by locusts— the swarming locust, the young locust, the destroying locust, and the devouring locust— My great army that I sent against you."

- ☐ Jeremiah 31:16–17

  "This is what the LORD says: 'Keep your voice from weeping and your eyes from tears, for the reward for your work will come, declares the LORD. Then your children will return from the land of the enemy. So there is hope for your future, declares the LORD, and your children will return to their own land.'"

- ☐ Genesis 50:20

  "As for you, what you intended against me for evil, God intended for good, in order to accomplish a day like this—to preserve the lives of many people."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] One repair: Each week, record one step of repair, such as an apology, a listening conversation, or a prayer.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Joel 2:25 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God can restore the years that were lost.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Repent" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Face the facts. Write what happened without exaggerating or minimizing.
- [ ] Apologize without excuses. Tell each child what you are sorry for, then listen.
- [ ] Seek help. Consider family counseling or a pastor if needed.
- [ ] Pray Joel 2:25. Ask God to restore what was lost.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I have ruined my children": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A step of repair
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I have ruined my children.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I carry deep regret over how I have hurt my children. Forgive me, give me courage to repair what I can, and redeem what I cannot. Restore the years that were lost. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.